

A Sociological Analysis of Parasite

Bryce Contreras

SOC 365

National University

The film *Parasite* explores the stratification of society's upper and lower classes through the lens of two families. Throughout the film, economic inequality is central to the story and shapes every character's decisions, regardless of their consequences. The themes in *Parasite* can be analyzed through the work of several classical sociological theorists, including Karl Marx, Émile Durkheim, and Thorstein Veblen. Marx's theories on class conflict and exploitation help explain the relationship between the Kim and Park families and highlight their differences. Veblen's concepts of both conspicuous consumption and conspicuous leisure are prevalent and reveal how wealth and social status are displayed throughout the motion picture. Finally, Émile Durkheim's ideas regarding social solidarity and anomie help explain the social divisions that develop between characters. While watching the movie via the perspectives of all three social theorists, we can see how inequality creates class conflict, status competition, and weakens societal cohesion.

Parasite was directed by Bong Joon-ho and released in 2019. The film follows the Kim family, who are living in destitution in Seoul, South Korea. The family consists of four members: Ki-taek (the father), Chung-sook (the mother), Ki-woo (the son), and Ki-jung (the daughter). The Kims are so poor that they find themselves lodged in a basement in the slums, before a turn of good fortune strikes them. Their lives begin to change for the better when Ki-woo is offered the opportunity to tutor the wealthy Park Family's daughter in English. Through a series of elaborate ploys and deception, the Kim family secures jobs within the Park household without revealing their relationship to one another. As the Kims become more involved in the Parks' lives, tensions between the two economic classes begin to emerge. The situation becomes very complicated after the discovery of a secret (third family) living beneath the Park's family home. This eventually concludes with violence, loss, and tragedy affecting all parties involved.

Karl Marx believed that economic relationships are the foundation of society and shape many aspects of social life. Capitalist societies can be broken down into two classes: the

bourgeoisie and the proletariat. In other words, the haves and the have-nots, or those who own the means of production and those who exchange labor for wages (Lecture 6). Marx argued that the interests of these classes are at odds because one group benefits from ownership while the other depends on employment for survival; more succinctly, one benefits at the **expense** of the other. This can be seen in the relationship between the wealthy Park family and the struggling Kim family: the former possesses great economic power and social status, while the latter must rely on their resourcefulness to scrape by. *Parasite* reflects class division and Marx's belief that economic inequality creates conflict between social groups (Antonio, 2007). Marx would likely have viewed the relationship between the Kim and Park families as an example of exploitation under capitalism. Every member of the Kim family is selling their time for wages, regardless of their position, whether as an English tutor, art instructor, housekeeper, or limo driver. Despite all being employed, the Kim family continues to live in squalor within their basement dwelling in the slums. The Parks, on the other hand, enjoy a comfortable lifestyle that relies on the labor of others. Marx argued that workers are forced to sell their labor power as a commodity to survive, while those who possess wealth and resources profit from it (Marx, 1844). Were he to watch the film, he would likely point out that each member of the Kim family was forced to abandon their true identity and lie, cheat, and steal their way into employment. This is an example of alienation. Work is no longer a meaningful expression of themselves, but instead nothing more than a means to survival (Marx, 1847). The Kim family was so poor that they were forced to abandon their morality and work the jobs that were available to them, regardless of how fulfilling they were. Above all else, though, the film did a great job of demonstrating Marx's idea of false consciousness. False consciousness is the concept that laborers lose perspective and begin to work against their own best interests (Lecture 6). Towards the end of the film, the Kim family discovers that the Parks' former housekeeper and her husband are already living in the residence's basement. The husband, Geun-se, has completely lost his mind and (literally) worships the very ground Park Dong-ik walks on. He bangs his head against the light switches

in the basement to illuminate Park's path as he arrives home. Marx would consider this to be a wonderful allegory for his idea.

While Marx focused on the economic relationships between social classes, Thorstein Veblen was interested in how wealth and status are displayed in society. Veblen argued that members of the upper class, or "leisure class," engage in conspicuous consumption and conspicuous leisure to garner attention and respect from their peers (Veblen, 1902). Conspicuous consumption is the practice of purchasing expensive goods and services to flaunt status and prestige. On the other hand, conspicuous leisure is the engagement in the "nonproductive consumption of time" (McCormick pg 199). This was a way to flex the fact that one is free from the obligations of wage labor, which, of course, is a luxury available to only a few. According to Veblen, both of these ideas display wealth and success, which is no less true today than when he wrote about them over a century ago.

There is ample evidence of both conspicuous consumption and leisure in the movie *Parasite*. The Park family is incredibly wealthy, and there are numerous visible indicators of this. For one, they employ multiple people to elevate their lifestyle and free themselves from many mundane and menial tasks that most ordinary people would have to perform, such as cooking, cleaning, and driving. Mr. Park has a chauffeur and an immensely nice vehicle that he is driven around in as a clear sign of conspicuous consumption. On their son's birthday, they decided to take an impromptu camping trip, which was subsequently canceled halfway through the drive due to inclement weather. On their way back, Mrs. Park called Chung-sook (mother) and instructed her to make a special meal called "ram-don" with less than ten minutes' notice. Mrs. Park had never even heard of the dish, but rushed to make it to satisfy her employer's desires. Were Veblen to see the film, he would likely speak to how the lower and working classes hardly have opportunities to take vacations, let alone impromptu ones. Furthermore, the short-notice phone call and dinner order are nothing more than entitlements reserved for the leisure class.

The third social theorist, Émile Durkheim, concentrated on the adhesives that held society together. He suggested that modern societies are moving away from generalist labor and towards a more complex, specialized workforce (Durkheim Overview Lecture). A consequence of this division of labor is that people would become more interdependent, leading to an increase in organic solidarity. Under organic solidarity, Durkheim believed that social cohesion is maintained through interdependence (Durkheim Overview Lecture). However, he also suggested that sudden social changes and growing division could weaken social bonds in what he referred to as anomie. Anomie being a state in which individuals feel disconnected from one another or society as a whole (Lecture 4). Durkheim's concepts are useful in interpreting the movie *Parasite* and the tensions between classes.

Durkheim's ideas of organic solidarity and anomie are evident throughout *Parasite*. The film portrays a society in which everyone is working in specialized roles and depends on one another to survive. The Kim family works as tutors, teachers, housekeepers, and drivers, and relies on money from the wealthy Kim family to get by. On the flip side, the Kim family relies on the Park family to sustain their lifestyle, which may be slightly distasteful but true nevertheless. This relationship is a perfect example of organic solidarity: two families from opposite ends of the socio-economic ladder, depending on one another. However, despite their dependence, there is very little relationship beyond that, as it does not go much further than transactional. The wealth disparity between the two families creates tension and resentment that gradually grows and eventually comes to a head. If Durkheim were to have watched the film, he would point out the dissolution of social bonds, as neither family could comprehend how the other lives. He would likely say both families were in a state of anomie, but particularly the Park family. The violence at the end of the film, where nearly 4 people die, could be viewed as evidence of a society that has broken down and social cohesion is at an all-time low.

If Marx, Veblen, and Durkheim were sitting together watching *Parasite*, they would likely agree that the movie highlights many major issues with modernity, but each would focus on

different causes. Marx would point out the evident class conflict between the Kim and Park families and explain that it is rooted in economic inequality. Furthermore, he would say that the existing conditions result from capitalism. Veblen may agree that equality is important, but he is more concerned with how the Park family exhibits conspicuous consumption with extravagant personal property and the ability to vacation and enjoy leisure. Durkheim would counter and guide the conversation towards the breakdown of social cohesion, particularly during the climax, when the Park family collides with the former housekeeper and her husband, which ends in a violent engagement, causing the death of several people. The three theorists would emphasize different aspects of the story, and they might even come to see that there is room for each of their ideas. All three can be correct without any of the others being wrong. Marx can explain the economic foundation, Veblen can enlighten others on peacocking, and Durkheim can speak about consequences. Together, their perspectives help provide a deeper understanding of the inner workings of social forces and how they relate to one another.

In conclusion, *Parasite* demonstrates many of the social and economic issues that each theorist, Marx, Veblen, and Durkheim, examined. Through Marx's perspective, the film reveals how economic inequality causes class conflict and that capitalism is inherently exploitative. Veblen's theories help explain how wealth is displayed through consumption and leisure, which can cause resentment and tension between social classes. Lastly, Durkheim's concepts of organic solidarity and anomie illustrate how the dissolution of social bonds can contribute to disorder. Although each theorist approaches society from different perspectives, their ideas help form a better understanding of how and why the Kim and Park families lived, and how this could result in the fatal, tragic way in which it ended. By examining *Parasite* through these lenses, it becomes clear that beneath the film lies a powerful commentary on modern society.

References

1. Antonio, R. J. (2007). Karl Marx. In G. Ritzer (Ed.), *The Blackwell companion to major contemporary social theorists* (pp. 115–164). Blackwell Publishing.
2. Durkheim Overview Lecture. (n.d.). Course lecture.
3. Lecture 4: Suicide: Anomie. (n.d.). Course lecture.
4. Lecture 6: Marx Economics. (n.d.). Course lecture.
5. Marx, K. (1844). *Estranged labour*. Marxists Internet Archive.
<https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1844/manuscripts/labour.htm>
6. Marx, K. (n.d.). *Karl Marx on alienation*. Pitzer College.
https://pzacad.pitzer.edu/~dsegal/1492/figures%20and%20texts%20not%20protected/Marx_Alienation.htm
7. McCormick, K. (2011). Thorstein Veblen. In G. Ritzer & J. Stepnisky (Eds.), *The Wiley-Blackwell companion to major social theorists* (pp. 185–204). Wiley-Blackwell.
8. Veblen, T. (1902). Conspicuous consumption. In *The theory of the leisure class: An economic study of institutions* (pp. 68–101). Macmillan.